

a long time, considering how both teams have been constructed and how their front offices have built up draft assets well into the future.

As the Finals began, the Knicks held a distinct advantage: they were far better rested. San Antonio had slogged through two gruelling series — a tough Western semifinal against the Timberwolves and a seven-game war with the Thunder — while New York had swept Cleveland in the East.

Having come through a tougher conference with a better regular-season record (62-20 to the Knicks' 53-29), the Spurs were the pick of some. That said, in the playoffs the regular-season record counts for little; match-ups and experience matter more.

The Knicks, with their ability to play five-out around Karl-Anthony Towns — perhaps the best shooting big man the game has seen — had already troubled the Spurs once that season, beating them 124-113 in the NBA Cup final. This was thanks to Towns' ability to draw Wembanyama from the paint and make him defend on the perimeter, lessening the impact of the world's best shot blocker and rim deterrent.

On balance, this promised to be a tough, close contest. And the games were indeed closely fought across the Finals. One statistic was telling — the Spurs led in close to 72 per cent of the minutes played across five games according to *ESPN Analytics*, after dominating the first quarters in most games.

But the Knicks always finished better, either aided by mental mistakes by the Spurs — such as the turnover by Wembanyama in Game 2 or a brain fade by Fox late in Game 4 when he could have retained possession and drawn a foul with the Spurs a point ahead, instead of getting blocked near the rim by Anunoby.

In fact, Game 4 was an epic and historic disaster for the Spurs. They led by 29 points (27 at half-time), but the Knicks mounted a decisive comeback in the second half — the biggest turnaround in NBA Finals history.



Game 5 also began similarly, with the Spurs dominating the first quarter and keeping it even in the second, but the Knicks were clinical again in the second half, completing another comeback to win the championship.

Fox, hampered by injury, was outshone by the younger Harper, who established himself as San Antonio's second-best player behind Wembanyama across the five games. But the Spurs' relative inexperience and their stars' misfiring in clutch moments were enough for the Knicks to seize the decisive stretches.

The moment belonged to the Knicks. Brunson was brilliant in Games 4 and 5, orchestrating both comebacks. In Game 5, he scored 45 points and was unstoppable. Anunoby provided solid two-way play throughout the playoffs and was stellar in the Finals, shooting 58 per cent from the field and a whopping 56 per cent from three. His defence against the Spurs' wings and guards was menacing, and he authored the winning play in Game 4 — a tip-in of Brunson's miss in the dying seconds.

Towns was relatively neutralised and became more of a non-factor in the later Finals games, largely due to foul trouble against Wembanyama. But coach Brown still managed to relatively hamper the French superstar, nicknamed the 'Alien', by deploying backup centre Mitchell

Homebound: The Larry O'Brien Trophy is finally back at what many consider the Mecca of basketball, as the Knicks capped a historic post-season run to win its first title since 1973.

Robinson to good effect.

Wembanyama, strong statistically but increasingly ineffective on the offence in crunch moments of every Spurs loss, was worn down by the rotating defence of Towns and Robinson, compounded by the inability of San Antonio's own backup centre, Luke Kornet, to replicate his steady regular-season role.

The Knicks' victory was followed by a collective burst of celebration in the Big Apple, giving long-awaited joy to a franchise that had not tasted success in over half a century, which included years of failure fashioned by the incompetence of its ownership.

The title this year was a culmination of a series of right decisions made by the Rose-led front office, clearly learning their lessons from the previous two decades' worth of failures, a major coaching change, and the chemistry of a squad that played unselfishly throughout the post-season. The Larry O'Brien trophy is now finally at what many consider the Mecca of basketball, after nearly five and a half decades.